Helping students understand and use subject vocabulary

Practical guidance for subject lecturers - D02-S1–S4

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Students need to understand subject terminology and use it accurately when explaining ideas, discussing problems and completing assessments. These strategies can be incorporated into ordinary subject teaching.

Why this helps

Vocabulary learning develops over time. Students need repeated encounters with important terms and opportunities to think about their meanings. Recalling a term from memory, revisiting it across lessons and using it in different contexts can strengthen learning. A glossary provides a reference; it becomes more useful when students regularly retrieve and apply its contents.

Recognising a term in a reading does not necessarily mean a student can use it independently. Plan opportunities both to interpret terminology and to use it in subject explanations.

1. Select and explain essential terms

Before the lesson, identify the terms students need to understand its main ideas and complete the task. Prioritise these rather than explaining every unfamiliar word.

For each essential term:

1. Show and say it. Display the written term while using it in your explanation.
2. Explain it clearly. Keep the disciplinary meaning accurate.
3. Illustrate it. Use an example, diagram, object or demonstration.
4. Check its application. Ask students to identify or explain a new example.

Worked example: opportunity cost

"*The **opportunity cost** is the value of the next-best alternative you give up when making a choice.*"

"*A business can fund either a delivery vehicle or new production equipment. It chooses the vehicle. If the equipment was its next-best alternative, the opportunity cost is the benefit forgone by not investing in that equipment*."

Check understanding: Present another choice and ask students what has been given up. Check that they distinguish opportunity cost from the amount of money spent.

If students struggle, consider whether the difficulty concerns the English term, the underlying concept or both. A translation may help connect the term to existing knowledge, but a new concept will still need explanation.

2. Distinguish subject and everyday meanings

Some familiar words have precise meanings in a discipline. Explain the difference explicitly without suggesting that the everyday meaning is incorrect.

Worked example: "*work*" in physics

Everyday use	Physics use
"Holding this heavy bag is hard **work."**	Mechanical **work** on an object involves a force acting through a displacement.

Explain:

"*In everyday language, **work** can mean effort. For this physics problem, we need to consider the force and the displacement.*"

- Check understanding: "*You hold a bag stationary. Are you doing mechanical work on the bag? Explain your answer*."
  The student should distinguish physical effort from mechanical work on the stationary object.
- Use the definition appropriate to your course. Avoid substituting approximate synonyms when the distinction between terms matters.

3. Build and use a course glossary

Give students a simple template and complete an entry together. Use a shared document, a worksheet or students' own notebooks.

Field	Example entry
Term	Opportunity cost
Meaning in this subject	The value of the next-best alternative forgone when making a choice.
Useful word combinations	Opportunity cost of a decision; higher opportunity cost.
Example in use	"The opportunity cost of using the room for storage is the benefit forgone from its next-best use."
Pronunciation support, if needed	A checked dictionary audio link or a note showing the stressed syllable.
Optional language note or visual	A translation, explanation in another language or diagram connecting the alternatives.

Introduce the fields gradually if needed. Students do not have to complete every field for every term.

Check selected entries for accurate meanings and examples. Students may draw on different languages to build understanding; keep the English terminology needed for the course visible.

4. Revisit terms through recall and application

Return to important terms after their introduction. Include brief opportunities to remember them before students consult their notes, followed by feedback.

When	What the teacher can do	Example
At the end of the lesson	Ask students to recall a term from a description. Then reveal and explain the answer.	"What term describes the value of the next-best alternative forgone?"
In a later lesson	Ask students to explain a term without looking, compare explanations and check their glossary.	"Explain opportunity cost to your partner. Then check whether your explanation includes the next-best alternative."
In a new case	Require students to apply the term to different information.	"Identify the opportunity cost in this business decision. Explain your reasoning."
During discussion or writing	Ask students to use selected terms where they help communicate the subject meaning.	"Explain your recommendation using opportunity cost where relevant."

These can be short, ungraded activities. If students cannot recall a term, provide a cue, let them check and try again. Correct inaccurate meanings before they practise them further.

A student who can repeat a definition may still need help applying the concept. Check their reasoning as well as their wording.

Before your next lesson

- Which terms are essential to the learning and task?
- Which familiar words have a different subject meaning?
- What example and checking question will you use?
- Which terms should enter the glossary?
- When will students recall and apply them again?

Sources and acknowledgements

This guide draws on:

University of Minnesota, *Teaching Support*: selecting important vocabulary and explaining terms.

Victorian Department of Education, *Introducing scientific language*: distinguishing everyday and scientific meanings.

TAEC Erasmus+ project (2017–2020), *EMI Handbook*, section 2.6.8, pp. 69–71: developing course glossaries.

Paul Nation, *The principles of vocabulary learning* (2022), published by TESOLANZ: repetition, retrieval, spacing and contextual use.

The worked examples, glossary template and classroom sequence were developed for this toolkit. The guidance requires contextual review before final publication.